

It's your first night in your own place.

Six things, in order of what you'll regret skipping. About an hour — and the first one matters more than the other five put together.

Stop unpacking and do these first. The instinct is to empty every box tonight. That ends at midnight with forty open boxes and nowhere to sleep. This is the order that makes tonight work and protects you later.

Nothing to sign up for. Start at one.

1 Photograph everything. Before another box comes in.

15 min

Every room, every wall, the floors, inside the oven and the fridge, and **close-ups of every mark, stain, chip and scuff you can find**. Your phone timestamps them. Don't tidy first — you want it exactly as handed over.

This is the one that's worth money, and it expires tonight. At the end of the tenancy, a deposit dispute comes down to who can show what the place looked like on day one. If you can, they pay. If you can't, you do — and "it was already like that" is not evidence. The moment you start filling the place, the chance is gone. Nobody tells you this, and it's the most expensive thing on the list.

2 Make the bed. Properly.

10 min

Find the sheets, put them on, make it up as though it's a normal Tuesday. **Before you're tired.**

Why so early. At one in the morning you will not want to be opening boxes looking for a fitted sheet, and that's exactly when you'll be doing it. Ten minutes now buys you the ability to stop whenever you want. It also means that whatever else the place looks like, one thing in it is finished.

3 Make the bathroom work.

10 min

Toilet paper on the holder. Soap by the sink. One towel hung up. Toothbrush and toothpaste somewhere they can sit. **That's the whole list** — don't unpack the rest of the box.

Four items and a room becomes usable. It's the room you'll need first and at the worst possible moment, and it's the cheapest one to finish.

4 Find three things and photograph them too.

10 min

The breaker box — where the switches are when the power cuts. **The water shutoff** — the main valve, plus the ones under the sink and behind the toilet. **The thermostat**, and whatever controls the hot water.

You want to know this before you need it, not during. A pipe fitting lets go at 2am roughly once in a lifetime, and the difference between a wet floor and a ruined one is whether you know where the valve is. Photograph each so you're not describing it to a landlord from memory.

5 Test the things that matter. Report anything broken tonight.

10 min

Hot water at every faucet. **Press the test button on every smoke alarm.** The lock and the deadbolt, with your own key, from outside. Every window opens and shuts and locks.

Anything wrong goes to the landlord in writing today — email, not a phone call, so there's a record with a date on it. Reporting a fault on day one is a maintenance request. Reporting it in month nine starts an argument about who broke it. Same fault, completely different conversation.

6 Clear one surface and one place to sit.

10 min

One table or counter with nothing on it, and one chair that isn't covered in things. **Then eat something.**

Somewhere to sit that isn't the bed. It sounds trivial and it's the difference between a place you're camping in and a place you live. It also gives you a surface for tomorrow, which is when the actual unpacking starts.

ONE THING TO CHECK TONIGHT

Press the test button on **every** smoke alarm, not just the one you can reach.

If any of them chirps, is silent, or isn't there at all, that goes to the landlord in writing tonight. In most places it's their legal obligation, and it is the one fault on this page that can actually kill you.

That's tonight. The boxes will keep.

Whatever you got through is what there was time for. The list runs in order of what costs most to have skipped, so wherever you stopped is the right place to have stopped.

If you only did the first one, you did the one that's worth money.

Before you unpack the rest.

Tomorrow the instinct will be to empty every box and then work out where things go. Everyone does it. It's also backwards, and it's why six months from now there'll be a drawer nobody can name the purpose of.

You will never again have this good a chance to decide where things live. Right now the place is empty and nothing has a home yet, so giving each thing one costs you nothing — you're putting it down for the first time either way. Do it in six months and it costs a weekend and an argument with yourself.

"Everything has its place. Do it now."

Those are Dave's. He's a real person, he's been saying them for decades, and he taught me how to run a house after I'd spent years failing at it. He's faintly embarrassed to tell anyone any of this, because he assumes everybody already knows. Almost nobody does. Nobody teaches it.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

You did the cheap version of everything.

Every item on that list took ten minutes tonight and would have cost hours, money or an argument later. **That's the whole method** — not working harder, just doing things while they're still small.

Dave calls it **preventative rather than crisis**. Tonight is the only night this year where almost everything in your life is still in the cheap column.